

Justin Nikolaus

AI Product Designer

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I'm a seasoned Product Designer with 10 years of experience designing multimodal, wearable, and AI-driven experiences across emerging devices. My work centers on defining the structure and behavior of multimodal interactions, ensuring voice, visuals, and system responses work together seamlessly. I'm recognized for incubating new lines of work, introducing new interaction models, and partnering across disciplines and organizations to shape future product direction.

Work Experience

AMAZON – Senior User Experience Designer

Jan 2016 - Present

Alexa Plus (Multimodal Orchestration)

- Led the Conversation CX workstream, defining how screen visuals + voice work together on the future of Alexa multimodal devices.
- Owned visual hierarchy, timing, pruning, and adaptive layouts to move beyond simple chat UI.
- Work demonstrated improved task completion and was validated through early user testing.
- Patent pending: multimodal orchestration framework for agent responses.

Wearables (Ear Buds and Smart Glasses)

- Led design for incubation efforts spanning smart glasses and next-gen hearables.
- Defined core interaction models for wearable agents, including notification systems.
- Explored social-aware and conversation-aware behaviors using ambient audio detection.
- Deliverables were incorporated into cross-org discussions and used as directional input for future devices.

Emotionally Aware & Socially Intelligent Agents

- Developed a framework enabling agents to infer user emotion and social context through multimodal sensors.
- Defined interaction scenarios that accounted for facial expression, conversational tone, and environmental cues, resulting in more appropriate and contextually relevant agent responses.
- Proposed interaction guidelines for privacy-aware behavior, child-safe media recommendations, and emotion-informed dialog adjustments.
- Work was well received by top leadership and was directed to be included in upcoming roadmaps.

Alexa Core Experiences

- Developed and enforced the design system for LEDs, sounds, and system states to improve consistency of Amazon Echo devices.
- Designed hardware button behavior, contextual response models, and multimodal multi-turn interactions for Alexa devices with screens.

Alexa In Space

- Designed the entire experience for Alexa aboard the Orion spacecraft, adapting dialog patterns and confirmations for astronaut workflows and the operational realities of spaceflight.
- Collaborated with NASA, Lockheed Martin, and Amazon engineering teams to deliver a reliable, hands-free assistant experience that ultimately launched as part of the Artemis I mission that traveled around the moon.

Alexa Voice Services (Manager)

- Managed a team of designers creating voice experiences for Alexa Voice Service (AVS), enabling device makers to integrate Alexa into consumer hardware like speakers, televisions, and automobiles.
- Developed design systems that maintained consistent UX and reduced support requests by 80%.

CROWDCAM – Cofounder, Designer

Jan 2015 - Dec 2016

CrowdCam & Sendframe

- Launched a startup that created a photo-sharing service for events and weddings.
- Created a web-based hosting platform and Android/iOS client apps (featured at a Weezer concert).

MICROSOFT – Senior User Experience Designer

Jan 2012 - Dec 2015

Cortana & Windows Phone

- Delivered the Cortana virtual assistant experience on Windows desktop, focusing on personalization, relevance, and user trust.
- Designed the system UI for Windows Phone OS and prototyped core experiences.

Skills

Design & Prototyping: Figma, Vibe Coding (VS Code + Cline), Figma Slides, Photoshop, Sketch, VoiceFlow

Methods: AI Frameworks, System design, Design thinking, Interaction design, Voice design, Public speaking

Domains: AI systems, Conversation design, Digital assistants, Multimodal systems, Interaction models

Hardware: Multimodal home hubs, Headless smart speakers, Ear buds, Smart glasses, Automotive, Spacecraft

Education

University of Wisconsin - Stout, Menomonie, WI

Graphic Design & Computer Science